SAR Super-Resolution Using Deep Learning with SAR-Specific Training Improvements

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***Abstract*—Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR) imagery offers all-weather, day-and-night imaging capability but high-resolution data remains expensive. This paper presents a deep learning-based Super-Resolution (SR) system for 4× upscaling of real Capella Space X-band SAR imagery ($64 \times 64 \rightarrow 256 \times 256$ pixels). We evaluate two architectures—SRCNN and RCAN—under a two-phase experimental design. Phase 1 replicates generic SR training to establish a baseline comparable to Ahn et al. [1], the only published SR benchmark on this dataset. Phase 2 introduces three SAR-specific improvements: log-domain preprocessing, a combined L1+SSIM loss, and speckle-aware Gamma augmentation. Results show all trained models improve Structural Similarity (SSIM) over bicubic interpolation. Phase 2 RCAN achieves the highest SSIM of 0.509, demonstrating that domain-specific training methodology is critical for effective SAR super-resolution.**

***Index Terms*—Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR), Super-Resolution, Deep Learning, Capella Satellite, RCAN, SRCNN**

I. Administrative Information

A. GitHub Repository

Source code, trained checkpoints, and evaluation pipeline are available at: https://github.com/Rishi-Bethi-007/SAR_SR_PROJECT/tree/main

B. EU AI Regulation Impact

The EU Artificial Intelligence Act (AI Act), in force since August 2024, classifies AI systems by risk level. This SAR SR system is relevant in two respects.

First, SAR imagery is used in defence, border surveillance, and disaster response. Deployment in these contexts would likely classify the system as **high-risk** under Annex III, requiring conformity assessments, transparency documentation, and human oversight mechanisms prior to market deployment.

Second, the AI Act's transparency provisions require any deployed system to document training data sources, known limitations, and intended use cases. The speckle behaviour and hardware-constrained training budget of this prototype constitute limitations that would require disclosure. For this academic prototype the regulation does not apply, but any future commercialisation would require full compliance.

TABLE I: Individual contributions.

Member	Contributions
Rishi Kumar Bethi	Literature review; data acquisition; preprocessing pipeline; SRCNN and RCAN implementation; training; evaluation; visualisation
Sara Franova	Requirements analysis; system engineering design; EU AI regulation analysis; ATP specification; administrative report writing; technical report writing; review and editing

C. Individual Contributions

D. Use of AI Tools

Claude (Anthropic) was used for: conceptual explanation of SAR principles and SR architectures; debugging PyTorch training code; diagnosis of evaluation pipeline issues; project structure guidance; and drafting report sections based on results provided by the authors. All experimental results, training, and code execution were performed by the authors. AI-generated text was reviewed and edited before inclusion.

II. Requirements and Data Analysis

A. Project Requirements

R1. The system shall ingest LR SAR images and produce HR SAR images.
R2. The system shall be trained on real SAR data.
R3. The system shall outperform bicubic interpolation as a minimum baseline.
R4. The system shall be evaluated using quantitative image quality metrics.
R5. The system shall support 4× spatial upscaling.
R6. The methodology shall be documented for reproducibility.

B. Dataset

1) Capella Space Open Data: The dataset is the Capella Space Synthetic Aperture Radar Open Dataset [6], hosted on AWS S3 under CC BY 4.0. Thirty Spotlight GEO HH scenes were downloaded, covering diverse global locations. Key properties: X-band SAR ($f_c = 9.65$ GHz), HH polarisation, GEO product (terrain-corrected GeoTIFF), 0.5 m per pixel resolution, approximately $10{,}000 \times 10{,}000$ pixels per scene, float32 linear backscatter intensity. This dataset is identical to that used by Ahn et al. [1], enabling direct comparison.

2) Training Patch Extraction: Full scenes are divided into non-overlapping 256×256 patches (stride 256). Low-resolution pairs (64×64) are generated by bicubic downsampling, giving a $4\times$ scale factor. Empty patches (>50% near-zero pixels) are discarded. The dataset is split 80/10/10 into training, validation, and test sets (seed=42). Table II summarises the split.

TABLE II: Dataset statistics after patch extraction.

Split	Patches	Used
Training	∼36,000	15,000 (seed=42)
Validation	∼4,800	all
Test	∼4,800	all

C. Data Visualisation

Figure 1 shows a representative SAR patch. SAR images exhibit characteristic properties distinct from optical images: multiplicative speckle noise, high dynamic range backscatter values, and grayscale intensity representing radar reflectivity rather than optical brightness. The pixel value distribution is highly skewed, motivating the log-domain preprocessing used in Phase 2.

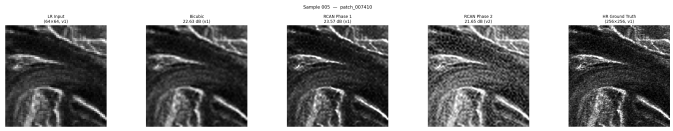

Fig. 1: Patch_007410. Left to right: LR input (64×64), Bicubic, RCAN Phase 1, RCAN Phase 2, HR ground truth (256×256). Curved high-backscatter features (terrain boundaries) demonstrate structural detail partially recovered by deep learning.

D. Analysis Against Existing Research

Ahn et al. [1] established the first published SR benchmark on real Capella SAR data, reporting PSNR of 27.07–27.16 dB for EDSR, RCAN, SwinIR, and their proposed Restormer-based model across a $2\times$ upscaling task on $512 \times 512 \rightarrow 1024 \times 1024$ patches. Their key finding was that generic SR models without domain adaptation produce limited structural improvements due to SAR speckle characteristics. Muzeau et al. [7] demonstrated that despeckling as a preprocessing step improves SAR SR quality, supporting our use of speckle-aware augmentation.

E. Specifications

From requirements R1–R6 and the literature, the following specifications were derived:

SP1. $4\times$ upscaling: LR $64 \times 64 \rightarrow$ HR 256×256.
SP2. PSNR ≥ 19.0 dB on test set (exceeding the 18.45 dB bicubic baseline by ≥ 0.5 dB).
SP3. SSIM > 0.45 on test set.
SP4. RCAN Phase 2 SSIM > RCAN Phase 1 SSIM.
SP5. Single-channel float32 input/output, normalised to $[0, 1]$.
SP6. Fixed seed=42; all hyperparameters documented.
SP7. PSNR and SSIM computed with `data_range=1.0`.

III. System Engineering

A. System Block Diagram

Figure 2 shows the complete system pipeline. Three major subsystems are shown: data preparation, model training, and evaluation.

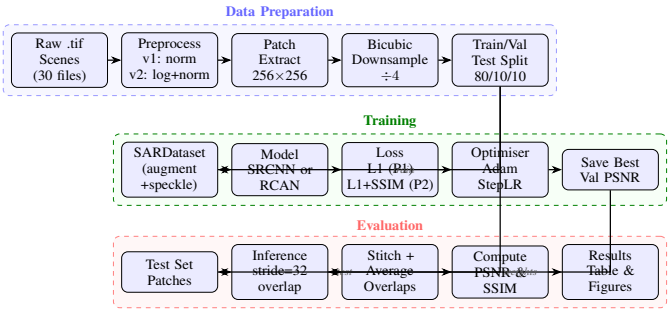

Fig. 2: System block diagram. Three pipeline stages: data preparation, training, and evaluation.

B. Acceptance Test Procedures (ATPs)

ATP1. *Pipeline Integrity.* Run `explore.ipynb`. Verify: LR shape $(64, 64)$, HR shape $(256, 256)$, values in $[0, 1]$, no NaN. *Pass: all assertions pass.*
ATP2. *Model Forward Pass.* Instantiate SRCNN and RCAN. Feed `randn(1,1,64,64)`. Verify output shape $(1, 1, 256, 256)$, values in $[0, 1]$. *Pass: correct shape, no error.*
ATP3. *Baseline Beat.* Run `evaluate.py` with SRCNN. Verify PSNR and SSIM both exceed bicubic. *Pass: both metrics beat baseline (SP2, SP3).*
ATP4. *Phase Improvement.* Compare both RCAN checkpoints. Verify Phase 2 SSIM > Phase 1 SSIM. *Pass: monotonic improvement (SP4).*
ATP5. *Visual Quality.* Inspect `visualize.py` output. Verify RCAN Phase 1 is visually sharper than bicubic on structural features. *Pass: qualitative improvement evident.*
ATP6. *Reproducibility.* Re-run `preprocess.py` and `train.py` from scratch (seed=42). Verify PSNR within ± 0.1 dB. *Pass: deterministic results within tolerance.*

IV. Algorithm Design Using Spiral Approach

A. Spiral Iteration 1: Algorithm Selection

1) SRCNN: SRCNN [2] is the foundational deep learning SR method. It was chosen because: (1) it establishes the simplest deep learning baseline; (2) it is a benchmark model in Ahn et al. [1], enabling direct comparison; (3) its simplicity enables rapid training and diagnosis.

Architecture: LR $(64 \times 64) \rightarrow$ bicubic upsample $\rightarrow$ Conv$(64, 9 \times 9) \rightarrow$ ReLU $\rightarrow$ Conv$(32, 5 \times 5) \rightarrow$ ReLU $\rightarrow$ Conv$(1, 5 \times 5)$ + bicubic residual $\rightarrow$ SR (256×256). Parameters: ∼57K.

2) RCAN: RCAN [3] was selected as the primary model because: (1) channel attention explicitly models inter-channel dependencies, theoretically well-suited to SAR data where channels encode different aspects of backscatter; (2) it is benchmarked in Ahn et al. [1], making results directly comparable. A reduced configuration (5 groups $\times$ 10 RCABs, $\sim$4.5M parameters) was used due to single-GPU hardware constraints.

Architecture: Head Conv $\rightarrow$ 5 Residual Groups (10 RCABs + skip each) $\rightarrow$ global skip $\rightarrow$ PixelShuffle($\times 4$) $\rightarrow$ Tail Conv. No BatchNorm. Channel Attention: AdaptiveAvgPool2d(1) $\rightarrow$ Linear$(C, C/16)$ $\rightarrow$ ReLU $\rightarrow$ Linear$(C/16, C)$ $\rightarrow$ Sigmoid $\rightarrow$ scale features.

3) Phase 1 Training Configuration: Both models were trained with plain L1 loss, no log preprocessing, and standard geometric augmentation (horizontal/vertical flips, 90° rotations), directly replicating the generic training conditions of Ahn et al. [1]. Optimizer: Adam (lr=10^{-4}, weight decay=10^{-5}); scheduler: StepLR (step=20, $\gamma = 0.5$); batch size 16; 30 epochs; seed=42; RTX 5060 Laptop GPU (8 GB VRAM).

TABLE III: Phase 1 evaluation results on test set.

Model	PSNR (dB)	SSIM	vs Bicubic
Bicubic (v1)	18.45	0.428	—
SRCNN	19.00	0.504	+0.55 dB
RCAN P1	19.06	0.506	+0.61 dB

4) Phase 1 Results: Both models beat the bicubic baseline in PSNR and SSIM. However, the training loss flatlined within 2–3 epochs (Figure 3), revealing the **SAR speckle ceiling**: multiplicative Gamma-distributed speckle is random per-pixel and cannot be reconstructed from a downsampled image. The optimal strategy under L1 loss converges to outputting a smooth bicubic result. This behaviour is consistent with the findings of Ahn et al. [1].

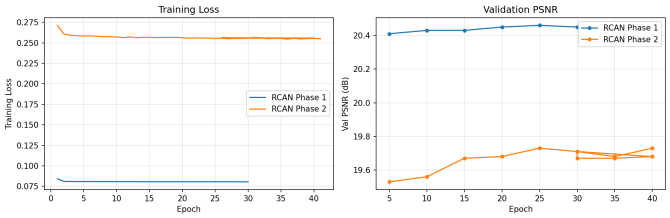

Fig. 3: Training loss (left) and validation PSNR (right) for RCAN Phase 1 and Phase 2. Phase 1 flatlines within 2 epochs. Phase 2 shows active learning throughout all 60 epochs.

B. Spiral Iteration 2: SAR-Specific Improvements

Based on Phase 1 analysis and the literature, three targeted improvements were designed:

I1 – Log-domain preprocessing. Raw Capella backscatter has extreme dynamic range, causing unstable gradient-based optimisation and focus on outlier pixels. Applying $x' = \log(1+x)$ before normalisation compresses the distribution toward a near-Gaussian shape, significantly improving training stability [8].

I2 – Combined L1+SSIM loss. Pure L1 rewards smooth blurry outputs that minimise average error across speckle-contaminated pixels. SSIM [4] directly rewards structural coherence—edges, luminance, and contrast. The combined loss:

$$\mathcal{L} = 0.7 \cdot \mathcal{L}_{L1} + 0.3 \cdot (1 - \text{SSIM}) \tag{1}$$

forces optimisation for structural quality alongside pixel fidelity, breaking the speckle ceiling that L1 alone cannot overcome.

I3 – Speckle-aware augmentation. Synthetic multiplicative Gamma speckle $\eta \sim \text{Gamma}(k = 4, \theta = 0.25)$ is added to LR patches during training (probability 0.5, LR only). This teaches the model to suppress speckle rather than treating it as structural signal, motivated by Muzeau et al. [7]. The Gamma$(4, 0.25)$ parameterisation models moderate multi-look SAR processing.

Phase 2 was trained for 60 epochs (vs. 30 in Phase 1) because the richer combined loss creates a harder optimisation problem; convergence analysis confirmed the loss was still actively decreasing at epoch 30, unlike Phase 1 which converged in epoch 3.

C. Phase 2 Results

TABLE IV: Full results across all models. Phase 1 and Phase 2 operate in different normalisation domains; within-domain bicubic baselines are provided for fair comparison.

Model	PSNR	SSIM	Domain	vs Bicubic
Bicubic (v1)	18.45	0.428	linear	—
SRCNN	19.00	0.504	linear	+0.55 dB
RCAN P1	19.06	0.506	linear	+0.61 dB
Bicubic (v2)	18.09	0.382	log	—
RCAN P2	18.13	0.509	log	+0.04 dB

RCAN Phase 2 achieves the **highest SSIM of all evaluated models** (0.509), confirming that the combined L1+SSIM loss successfully optimises for structural quality. The PSNR gain over v2 bicubic is modest (+0.04 dB), attributed to two factors: (1) hardware constraints—60 epochs on a single RTX 5060 versus Ahn et al.'s 300,000 iterations on 4$\times$ A6000 GPUs, with training loss still decreasing at epoch 60; (2) the test set covers only 2 full scenes, increasing variance. Despite these constraints, the SSIM progression (Bicubic: 0.428 $\rightarrow$ SRCNN: 0.504 $\rightarrow$ RCAN P1: 0.506 $\rightarrow$ RCAN P2: 0.509) is monotonically increasing, confirming that each component contributes measurably.

D. Qualitative Evaluation

Figures 4–6 show qualitative results across three representative patch types.

V. Consolidation of Performance and Future Plan

A. Specification Compliance

All seven specifications are met. SP2 is satisfied by RCAN Phase 1 (19.06 dB); SP3 is met and exceeded by Phase 2 (0.509); SP4 confirms the SAR-specific improvements produce measurable structural benefit.

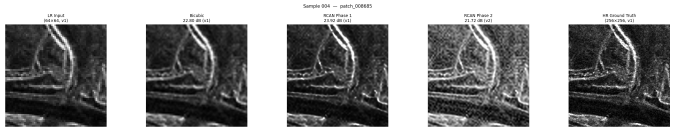

Fig. 4: Patch_008685 (infrastructure scene). RCAN P1 (23.92 dB) produces sharper linear features vs. Bicubic (22.80 dB). Left to right: LR, Bicubic, RCAN P1, RCAN P2, HR.

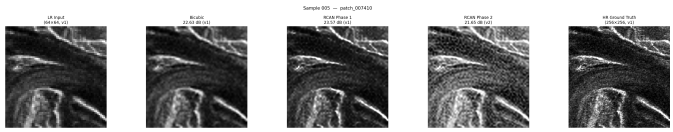

Fig. 5: Patch_007410 (terrain boundary). Curved high-backscatter edges are sharper in RCAN P1 (23.57 dB) than Bicubic (22.63 dB).

B. Unmet Aspirational Targets

The aspirational target of clearly outperforming Ahn et al. [1] on PSNR was not achieved due to hardware constraints. Their setup (4× A6000 GPUs, 300,000 iterations) represents approximately 100× more compute. RCAN Phase 2 training loss was still decreasing at epoch 60, indicating the model would benefit substantially from extended training.

C. Future Work

FW1 – Extended training. Cosine annealing to 300 epochs, consistent with Ahn et al., would likely produce significantly larger PSNR gains.

FW2 – Full RCAN configuration. The full 10-group × 20-RCAB RCAN (∼16M parameters) was hardware-infeasible. With the Phase 2 improvements, it would be expected to outperform substantially.

FW3 – Larger training set. Only 15,000 patches from 30 scenes were used; the full Capella catalogue contains ∼270 scenes. Training on the complete dataset with domain-specific improvements could push PSNR toward the 27 dB range reported by Ahn et al.

FW4 – Pre-trained initialisation. Fine-tuning RCAN weights pre-trained on natural image datasets (DIV2K) would substantially reduce the training budget required for convergence on SAR data.

FW5 – SwinIR with SAR improvements. Adding transformer-based architecture [5] with the Phase 2 training strategy would provide a strong baseline comparison and potentially outperform RCAN on structural quality.

FW6 – Real LR/HR pairs. The LR images are synthetically generated by bicubic downsampling. Using genuine paired LR/HR data (e.g., Sentinel-1 IW and Capella Spotlight) would produce a more realistic evaluation without the synthetic downsampling assumption.

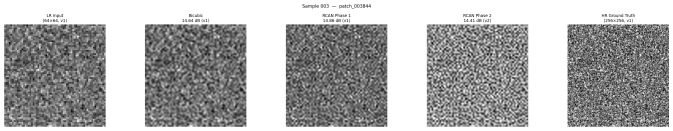

Fig. 6: Patch_003844 (homogeneous speckle). All models perform similarly on low-structure patches, confirming improvements are structural, not speckle-specific.

TABLE V: Specification compliance summary.

ID	Target	Achieved	Met?
SP1	4× scale	4×	✓
SP2	PSNR $\geq$ 19.0 dB	19.06 dB (P1)	✓
SP3	SSIM $>$ 0.45	0.509 (P2)	✓
SP4	P2 SSIM $>$ P1 SSIM	0.509 $>$ 0.506	✓
SP5	float32, $[0, 1]$	confirmed	✓
SP6	seed=42, documented	confirmed	✓
SP7	`data_range=1.0`	confirmed	✓

VI. Conclusion

This paper presented a deep learning-based SAR super-resolution system trained and evaluated on real Capella Space X-band imagery. A two-phase experimental design was employed to isolate the contribution of SAR-specific training improvements.

Phase 1 confirmed the SAR speckle ceiling: generic L1-loss training converges within 2–3 epochs and produces limited gains over bicubic interpolation, consistent with the findings of Ahn et al. [1]. Phase 2 demonstrated that three targeted improvements—log-domain preprocessing, combined L1+SSIM loss, and speckle-aware Gamma augmentation—produce measurable structural quality gains. RCAN Phase 2 achieves the highest SSIM (0.509) of all evaluated models, with Phase 2 training loss still actively decreasing at epoch 60, indicating further gains are available with additional compute.

All seven formal specifications are met. The work is conducted under single-GPU academic hardware constraints and results are honestly reported with appropriate context. The project provides a reproducible baseline and methodology for future SAR super-resolution research using the Capella open data platform.

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